Fog

The big idea

Fog by **Carl Sandburg** is a tiny **free-verse** poem of six lines in which the poet compares the fog to a **cat**. The whole poem is one **extended metaphor**: fog arrives, sits, and leaves exactly like a cat.

What the poem says

- The fog comes **on little cat feet** — silently, softly.
- It **sits** looking over the **harbour and city** on **silent haunches** (a cat sitting on its hind legs).
- And then it **moves on** — suddenly, without warning.

THE EXTENDED METAPHOR

The poet never uses "like" or "as". He simply speaks of the fog **as if it were a cat** throughout, so the comparison is a **metaphor** sustained across the poem.

How the fog is like a cat

Cat	Fog
walks silently on soft paws	arrives without a sound
sits on its haunches and watches	hangs over the harbour and city, covering it
moves away when it wishes	lifts and disappears unpredictably

Poetic devices

- **Extended metaphor:** fog = cat.
- **Personification:** fog "sits looking", "moves on".
- **Imagery:** visual images of the harbour and city under fog.
- **Free verse:** no rhyme scheme or fixed metre.
- **Alliteration:** "**s**its ... **s**ilent"; "**c**at ... **c**ity".
- **Enjambment** and very short lines that mimic the cat's quiet movement.

IT IS NOT A SIMILE

There is no "like" or "as" in the poem — call it a **metaphor** (extended metaphor), not a simile.

About the poet

Carl Sandburg was an American poet who wrote about Chicago and city life in plain, everyday language. Fog over the harbour city of Chicago may have inspired this poem.

Theme and value points

- Nature is mysterious and silent, like a cat.
- Even ordinary weather can be seen with imagination.
- Change in nature is quiet and temporary.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

What does the poet compare the fog to? Which words show this? Is the poem a free verse? Does it have a rhyme scheme? Write a short poem comparing rain or the sun to an animal (creative questions sometimes appear).

Quick recap

- Carl Sandburg; six lines; free verse.
- Fog comes on little cat feet, sits on silent haunches, moves on.
- Device: extended metaphor + personification.

Practice questions

1. To what does the poet compare the fog?
   (a) A tiger (b) A ghost (c) A cat (d) A cloud
2. The comparison in "Fog" is best called
   (a) a simile (b) an extended metaphor (c) an allusion (d) a pun
3. What does the fog look over?
   (a) Fields and forests (b) Mountains (c) Harbour and city (d) A garden
4. "Haunches" are
   (a) ears (b) paws (c) the hips and thighs an animal sits on (d) whiskers
5. Which feature of a cat does the fog's arrival show?
   (a) Its loud mewing (b) Its sharp claws (c) Its love for milk (d) Its silent, soft-footed movement
6. "Fog" is written in
   (a) free verse (b) rhyming couplets (c) abab quatrains (d) sonnet form
7. How does Carl Sandburg describe the fog? Which poetic device does he use?

Answers: 1. c 2. b 3. c 4. c 5. d 6. a 7. see notes